



How to Write an Essay

A Cross-Subject Guide and Template

An Official ONSITES High School Student Guide

ONSITES High School

How to Use This Guide

This guide teaches one method for writing essays that works in every ONSITES High School course. The topic changes from class to class, but the way you build a strong essay does not.

Read **Parts 1 to 3** to learn the method, the style, and how your work is scored. Use **Part 4** to set up and format your essay. The template at the back is ready to fill in, so you do not have to build the format yourself.

You do not need to read everything at once. Use the contents on the next page to jump to what you need. Return to the rubric and the self-check each time you write, and you will improve faster.

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1. Foundations

1.1 Why Writing Works the Same in Every Course

At ONSITES High School you write essays in many courses: English, U.S. History, U.S. Government, Economics, Psychology, and more. The topic changes from one course to the next. The rules for a strong essay do not.

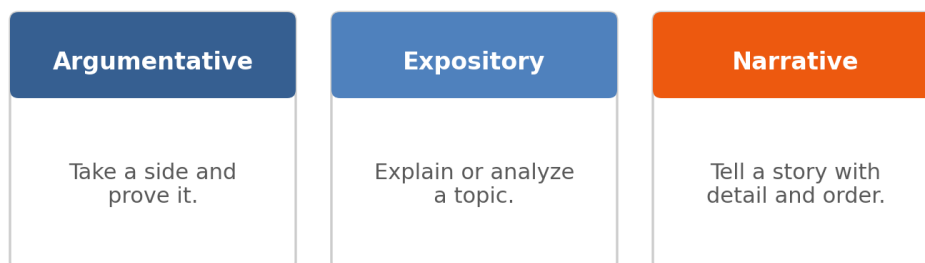
This is by design. The curriculum follows Florida's B.E.S.T. Standards (Benchmarks for Excellent Student Thinking), which treat writing as one skill used across every subject. In every course you write in response to texts: you read one or more sources, take your own position, and support it with evidence you cite.

Learn the method in this guide once, and you can use it everywhere. That is good news. The work you put in now pays off in every class you take.

1.2 Essay Types

Almost every essay you write is one of three types. Knowing the type tells you what your reader expects.

- **Argumentative.** You take a position and defend it with reasons and evidence. Most History, Government, and Economics essays are argumentative, and so are many English essays.
- **Expository.** You explain or analyze a topic. You are not trying to win an argument. You are making something clear. Many Science and Psychology essays are expository.
- **Narrative.** You tell a true or invented story with detail and order. This type appears mostly in English.



The three essay types and what each one asks you to do.

To find the type, look at the verb in the prompt. *Argue*, *defend*, and *evaluate* signal an argumentative essay. *Explain*, *describe*, and *analyze* signal an expository one.

1.3 Understanding the Prompt

Before you write a single word, read the prompt closely. The prompt tells you the type of essay, the topic, and any limits, such as how many sources to use or how long to write. The command verb is the key. It tells you what the reader wants you to do.

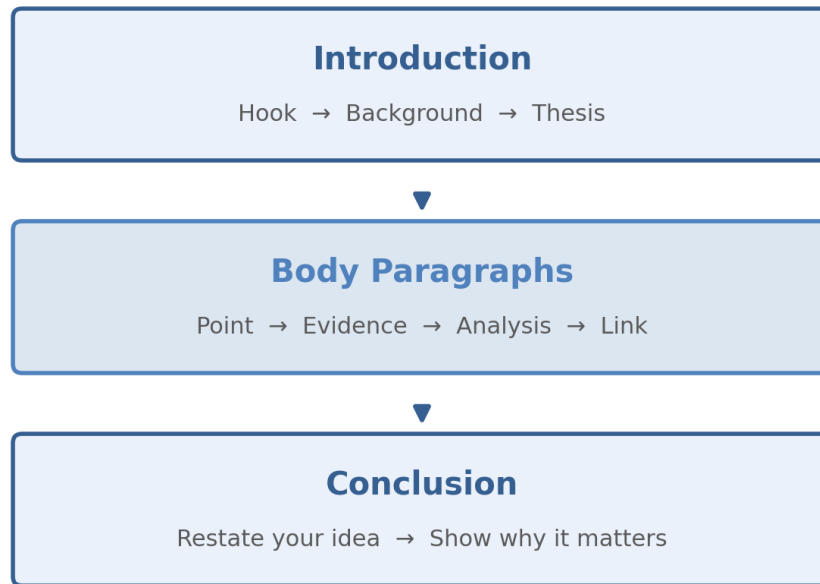
Command verb	What it asks you to do
Argue / Defend	Take a clear side and prove it with reasons and evidence.
Explain / Describe	Make something clear, step by step, without taking a side.
Analyze	Break something into parts and show how the parts work together.
Evaluate	Judge how good, true, or effective something is, and give reasons.
Compare / Contrast	Show the similarities and differences between two things.
Summarize	Restate the main points briefly in your own words.

Tip

Underline the command verb and circle the topic. Note any limits on length or sources. If you answer the wrong verb, even a well-written essay loses marks.

2. Writing the Essay

Here is the shape of every essay you will write. The rest of this part builds each piece.

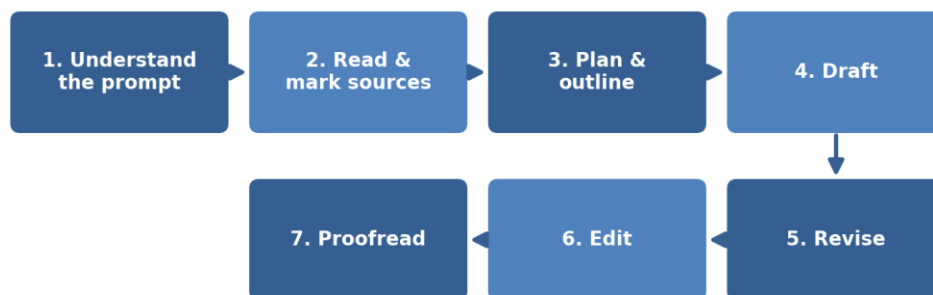


The three parts of an essay.

2.1 The Writing Process

Strong writing is built in stages. Skilled writers almost never write a finished essay in one pass. Build these steps into every essay, and the work feels easier.

1. **Understand the prompt.** Find the command verb, the topic, and the limits.
2. **Read and annotate the sources.** Read once for meaning, then again to mark parts that fit the prompt.
3. **Plan and outline.** Decide your thesis and your main points before you draft.
4. **Draft.** Write the whole essay from your plan. Do not stop for small errors yet.
5. **Revise.** Fix the big things: your thesis, your structure, and your evidence.
6. **Edit.** Fix grammar, spelling, and punctuation.
7. **Proofread.** Read once more, slowly, to catch the last typos.



2.2 Planning and Outlining

A short plan saves time and keeps you on track. Brainstorm your ideas, group them into two or three main points, and match each point to evidence from the sources. Then put the points in a logical order.

A simple outline looks like this:

- **Thesis:** your main idea in one sentence.
- **Point 1** plus the evidence that supports it.
- **Point 2** plus its evidence.
- **Point 3** plus its evidence.
- **Conclusion:** why your idea matters.

2.3 The Thesis Statement

Your thesis is the single most important sentence in your essay. It states your main idea or position in one clear sentence, usually at the end of your introduction. A strong thesis is specific and, in an argumentative essay, arguable.

Example: weak to strong

Weak: School start times are important.

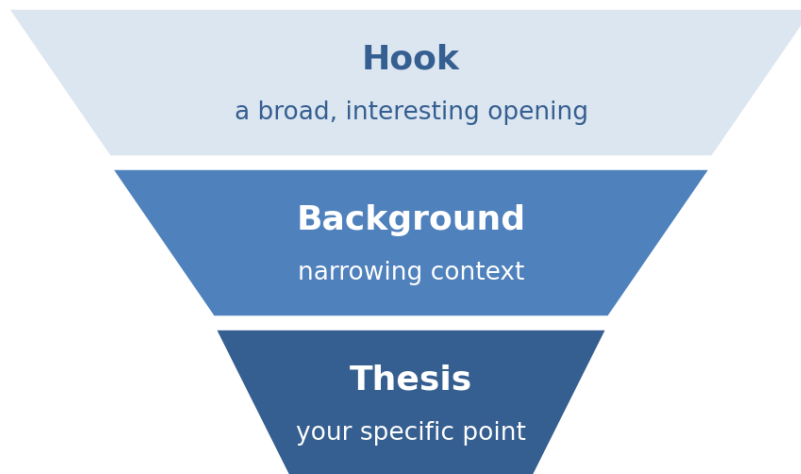
Stronger: ONSITES High School should start the day later, because more sleep improves student health, focus, and grades.

The stronger thesis takes a clear position and previews the reasons the essay will develop.

2.4 The Introduction

A strong introduction has three parts: a hook to catch interest, a little background, and your thesis at the end. Open with one of these hooks:

- A question related to the topic.
- A surprising fact or statistic.
- A short quotation from a source.
- A brief anecdote, a small story tied to the topic.
- A statement of why the topic matters.



broad → specific

An introduction moves from a broad hook to a specific thesis.

Example: a model introduction

Most teenagers do not get enough sleep on school nights. Research links early start times to tired students and lower grades. Yet many schools still begin before eight in the morning. ONSITES High School should start the day later, because more sleep improves student health, focus, and grades. Notice how the paragraph opens with a fact, adds context, and ends with the thesis.

2.5 Body Paragraphs

Each body paragraph makes one point that supports your thesis. A reliable pattern is **Point, Evidence, Analysis, Link**.

- **Point.** State the one idea this paragraph will prove.
- **Evidence.** Give cited proof from a source.
- **Analysis.** Explain how the evidence proves your point. This is where you show your thinking.
- **Link.** Connect the point back to your thesis.

Point the one idea this paragraph proves

Evidence cited proof from a source

Analysis explain how it proves your point

Link tie the point back to your thesis

Every body paragraph follows the same four moves.

Example: an annotated body paragraph

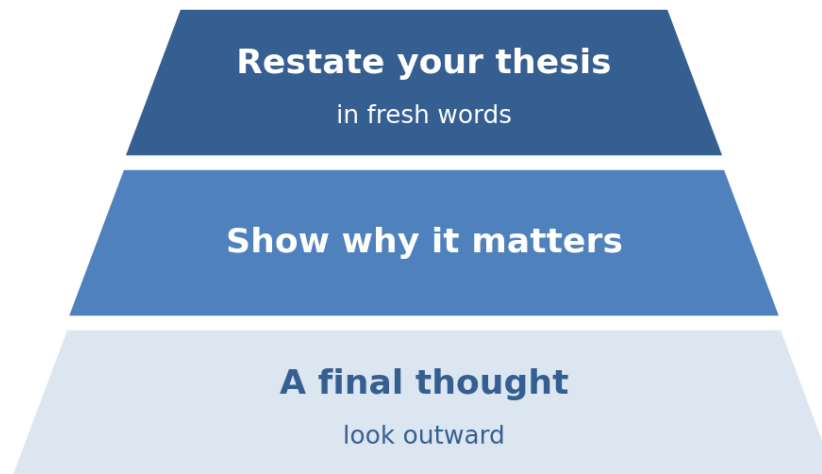
More sleep improves student focus. A study of high school students found that those who slept at least eight hours scored higher on attention tests (Lee, 2019). This matters because attention is the basis of learning: a focused student understands more in class and remembers more later. A later start time would give students that focus, which supports the case for changing the schedule.

Point: the first sentence. **Evidence:** the cited study. **Analysis:** the explanation of why focus matters. **Link:** the final sentence ties back to the thesis.

2.6 The Conclusion

Your conclusion restates your main idea in fresh words and shows why it matters. Do not add new evidence. Close with one of these moves:

- Restate your thesis in new words.
- Summarize your main points briefly.
- Add a final insight that follows from your essay.
- Offer a solution or make a prediction.



specific → broad

A conclusion moves from your specific point back out to why it matters.

2.7 Transitions and Signal Words

Transitions guide your reader from one idea to the next. Pick words that match what you are doing.

Purpose	Words you can use
To add an idea	also, in addition, furthermore, moreover
To contrast	however, on the other hand, in contrast, yet
To show cause or effect	because, as a result, therefore, so
To give an example	for example, for instance, such as
To put in order	first, next, then, finally
To conclude	in conclusion, overall, to sum up

2.8 Working with Evidence

Evidence is proof from your sources. You can use it in three ways: **quote** the exact words, **paraphrase** by restating an idea in your own words, or **summarize** by giving the main point briefly. In all three, name where it came from.

Never drop a quotation on its own. Introduce it, then explain it. Your own thinking, the analysis, is what earns the higher marks.

Optional sentence starters (training wheels)

Use these to get going, then aim to write without them as your skills grow.

According to (Author, year), ____.

This evidence shows that ____.

One reason is _____. For example, _____.

This connects to my thesis because _____.

3. Style, Sources, and Scoring

3.1 Citing Sources in APA

ONSITES High School uses APA style. Cite each source in the text with the author and the year. Then list every source on a References page. Citation is not optional: see the rubric note in section 3.5.

Example: how APA citations look

In the text: (Smith, 2020), or: Smith (2020) argued that ____.

A book on the References page: Author, A. A. (Year). *Title of the book*. Publisher.

A website on the References page: Author, A. A. (Year, Month Day). *Title of the page*. Site Name.
URL

Start the References page on a new page. Center the bold title References. List sources in alphabetical order by author, and indent every line after the first half an inch.

3.2 Academic Integrity

Plagiarism means using someone else's words or ideas without giving credit. It is a serious breach of academic honesty. Avoid it in three ways: cite every source you use, put ideas into your own words, and use quotation marks around any words you copy exactly. When in doubt, cite.

3.3 Voice, Tone, and Academic Vocabulary

Academic writing is formal. In your essay, avoid slang and contractions, and do not address the reader as "you." Be precise, and choose strong academic words.

Stronger word choices

Instead of *good*, try effective, valuable, or significant.

Instead of *a lot of*, try many, considerable, or numerous.

Instead of *shows*, try demonstrates, reveals, or indicates.

Keep a list of useful academic words from your reading, and practice using them.

3.4 Common Mistakes to Avoid

Most lost marks come from a few common problems. Check for these before you submit.

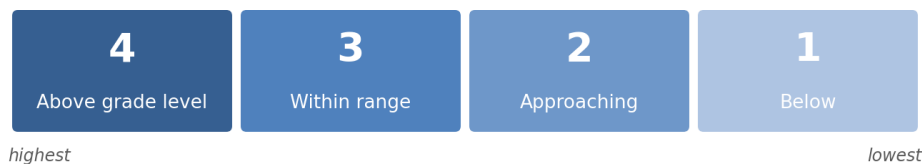
- **No clear thesis.** Add one clear position at the end of your introduction.
- **Evidence with no explanation.** Always explain how the evidence proves your point.
- **Missing citations.** Cite every source. Uncited evidence cannot score well.
- **Too informal.** Remove slang and contractions.
- **One giant paragraph.** Use one main point per paragraph.

3.5 The Rubric and How to Move Up a Level

Every subject scores your essay on the same three areas, taken from Florida's B.E.S.T. writing rubric. Each area is scored from **4** (highest) down to **1** (lowest).

- **Purpose and Structure:** a clear main idea in a logical order.
- **Development:** strong, cited evidence, explained in your own words.
- **Language:** correct, varied, standard English.

Area	4	3	2	1
Purpose and Structure	Main idea is sharp and holds throughout. Transitions tie ideas together.	Main idea is clear and mostly holds. Order is logical.	Main idea is unclear or fades. Transitions are weak.	Main idea is missing or confusing. Little order.
Development	Evidence from several sources is woven in and cited. Academic vocabulary sharpens ideas.	Relevant evidence supports your points and is cited.	Evidence is thin or loosely linked. Citations missing.	Evidence missing or confusing. Citations missing.
Language	Sentences are varied and fluid. Conventions are clean.	Sentences vary. Conventions mostly correct.	Sentences simple or uneven. Errors frequent.	Heavy errors that often blur meaning.



What each score means, from 4 (highest) down to 1 (lowest).

The one rule that matters most

If you do not cite your evidence, your Development score cannot rise above a **2**, however good the rest of the essay is. Always cite.

To move up a level:

- **Purpose and Structure:** sharpen your thesis and add clear transitions.

- **Development:** add more cited evidence, and explain each piece in your own words.
- **Language:** vary your sentences and proofread carefully for errors.

3.6 Revising, Editing, and the Self-Check

These three steps are different. **Revise** the big picture: is the thesis clear, does every paragraph support it, is the evidence strong? **Edit** the small things: grammar, spelling, and punctuation. **Proofread** one last time for typos. A few strategies help:

- Read your essay out loud. Your ears catch what your eyes skip.
- Make a reverse outline: write the point of each paragraph in the margin, then check the order.
- Fix one kind of error per pass, rather than everything at once.

Self-check before you submit

My introduction ends with one clear thesis.

Every body paragraph supports that thesis.

I support each point with cited evidence and explain it.

My conclusion restates my idea and shows why it matters.

I used transitions between ideas.

My essay follows the ONSITES High School format.

I read it aloud and fixed grammar, spelling, and punctuation.

4. Format and Template

4.1 Formatting Your Essay

Format every essay using the ONSITES High School standard. Set your document up this way before you start.

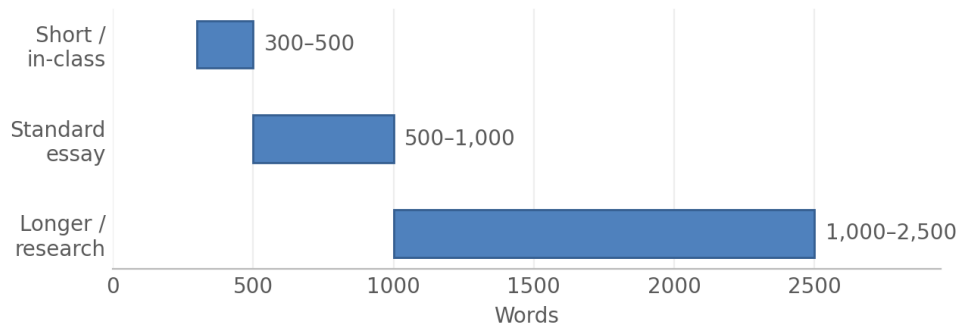
- **Paper size:** US Letter (8.5 by 11 inches) or A4.
- **Margins:** 1 inch on all four sides.
- **Line spacing:** 1.5 throughout.
- **Font:** Times New Roman, 12 point.
- **Paragraphs:** no first-line indent; leave a 6-point space after each.
- **Page numbers:** add a page number in the top right of every page after the cover page.

Use no more than three heading levels, and only when the essay is long enough to need them. Number each heading and style it as shown:

Level	Font	Size	Style	Numbering
Heading 1	Times New Roman	14 pt	Bold	1, 2, 3
Heading 2	Times New Roman	12 pt	Bold	1.1, 1.2
Heading 3	Times New Roman	12 pt	Bold italic	1.1.1

Word count. Always follow the count your assignment gives. When none is given, these are typical ranges for high school work:

Essay type	Typical length
Short or in-class essay	300 to 500 words
Standard essay (argumentative, expository, analysis, narrative)	500 to 1,000 words
Longer or research-based essay, including AP level	1,000 to 2,500 words



Typical word-count ranges for high school essays.

English and History essays rely on extended analysis and often sit at the higher end of a range. Shorter response essays in Government, Economics, Psychology, and Sociology often sit lower. Word counts usually do not include the cover page or the References page.

4.2 The Template

The pages that follow are ready to fill in. The cover page and body are already set in the correct format. Replace the placeholders with your own work, and delete the grey notes before you submit.

Cover page. Fill in the placeholders. Delete this note before you submit.



[Essay Title]

Course: [Course Name]

Student: [Your Full Name]

Teacher: [Teacher's Name]

Grade Level: [Grade Level]

Date: [Submission Date]

Body. Write your essay using these headings. Delete this note and any headings you do not need before you submit.

1. Introduction

[Write your introduction here. End it with your thesis: one clear sentence stating your main idea.]

2. Body

2.1 [First main point]

[State your point. Give cited evidence, such as (Author, year). Explain how the evidence proves your point. Link back to your thesis.]

2.1.1 [Optional sub-point]

[Use a third-level heading only when a point needs to be broken down further.]

2.2 [Second main point]

[State your next point and support it with cited evidence.]

3. Conclusion

[Restate your main idea in fresh words and show why it matters. Add no new evidence.]

References

[Author, A. A. (Year). Title of the source. Publisher or website.]

5. Reference and Support

5.1 Glossary

Thesis. the one sentence that states your main idea or position, usually at the end of the introduction.

Claim. a point you argue is true and then support with evidence.

Evidence. proof from a source, such as a fact, quotation, or example.

Analysis. your explanation of how the evidence proves your point.

Citation. a short note that shows where evidence came from, in APA: (Author, year).

Paraphrase. restating a source's idea in your own words, still cited.

Summary. a brief restatement of the main points of a source in your own words.

Transition. a word or phrase that links one idea to the next, such as *however* or *as a result*.

Hook. the opening line of an essay that catches the reader's interest.

Topic sentence. the sentence that states the main point of a paragraph.

Argumentative essay. an essay that takes a position and defends it with evidence.

Expository essay. an essay that explains or analyzes a topic without taking a side.

Narrative essay. an essay that tells a story with detail and order.

Rubric. the chart that shows how an essay is scored.

References. the list of all sources used, on its own page at the end of the essay.

5.2 Multilingual Writing Tips

Many students here write academic essays in English for the first time. These habits help.

- **Build academic vocabulary.** Keep a list of formal words from your reading and practice using them.
- **Write your ideas first, then improve the language.** Get your thoughts down, then fix the wording when you revise.
- **Use your sources' key terms.** If a source says *federalism* or *scarcity*, use that exact word. It shows you understand.
- **Read your work out loud.** Hearing your sentences catches errors your eyes miss.
- **Use American English.** Spell the American way: *color*, not *colour*; *organize*, not *organise*.

5.3 Where to Get Help

You are not on your own. Ask your teacher when a prompt is unclear or when you want feedback on a draft. Use the rubric in section 3.5 and the self-check in section 3.6 every time you write. Return to this guide whenever you need a reminder of the method.

ONSITES High School teaches writing as one skill you carry across your whole education. Learn this method once, and you are ready to write a strong essay in any course.